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At a moment of acute regional tension, the immediate question was simple: how did the war feel inside Saudi Arabia? The answer was complex. Saudi Arabia is the size of western Europe, and the experience of the war varied sharply by geography. The Eastern Province, overseeing the Gulf and closer to Iran, felt it differently from the western or central regions like Riyadh or Jeddah. That scale mattered. In practical terms, even if something happened in one part of the country, people elsewhere did not feel its effects directly. That was one reason why the war felt less intense here than in some neighbouring, smaller-sized Gulf countries.

Another factor is political. Iran was arguably violating the Beijing Declaration of 2023, which pushed for a five-point plan to ensure regional peace, including cessation of attacks in the Gulf region, but Saudi Arabia was respecting it. That meant restraint—no US attacks launched from Saudi territory or airspace towards Iran. This helped limit direct escalation.

There were also structural reasons. Saudi Arabia has strong security arrangements, including recent agreements with the United States and longstanding ties with Pakistan. More importantly, it has a well-armed and well-resourced military. Bringing Saudi Arabia, Custodian of the Two Holy Mosques, directly into the conflict would dramatically escalate the situation, potentially igniting a much wider regional crisis. That risk alone acted as a deterrent. For now, there is visible restraint across the region, thanks to an 11th-hour ceasefire brokered by Pakistan with Chinese backing.

That said, the threat was real. For weeks, there were almost daily attacks—ballistic missiles and drones—most of which were intercepted. The targets were largely economic: oil facilities such as those in the southeast oil field of Al Shaiba. This aligned with a broader strategy—to make the war economically costly for everyone rather than purely ideological. When you consider that Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar have already seen disruptions to their energy production, even partial outages add up. A million barrels a day taken offline is not just a regional issue but a global one.

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Saudi Arabia, however, managed to cushion the blow. Geography helped, but so did preparation. One of the key tools was the East-West Pipeline, or Petroline, built in the early 1980s as a contingency against precisely this kind of disruption. It allows oil from the Eastern Province to be transported westwards and shipped via the Red Sea port of Yanbu, bypassing chokepoints like the Strait of Hormuz. In the current situation, Saudi Arabia managed to route roughly 70 per cent of its output through this pipeline—a significant achievement under crisis conditions.

But if the physical impact was contained, the economic impact is only beginning. It would be a mistake to assume business as usual. Even if a temporary truce is in place, and the war ended tomorrow, recovery would not be immediate. For instance, Qatar's LNG facilities, currently offline, would take weeks to restart. That is lost revenue in a highly time-sensitive global market. A recent United Nations estimate puts the cost to Gulf countries at around $200 billion—and that is likely conservative. It does not account for lost oppor-